THE WHOLE TREATMENT JOURNEY

Pembrolizumab and chemotherapy: the whole breast pathway

Neoadjuvant → surgery → adjuvant · triple-negative early breast cancer

This is NCCP 00857: four 3-week cycles of carboplatin/weekly paclitaxel with pembrolizumab, then four 3-week AC cycles with pembrolizumab, surgery, and postoperative pembrolizumab when appropriate.

Read from left to right. Columns show stages, not equal lengths of time. This is a general plan: no dates or personal information are needed. Your team confirms which steps apply and arranges appointments.

Treatment, tests and reviews across the course

Care / check	Before treatment	Phase 1 · about 12 weeks	Phase 2 · about 12 weeks	Surgery and pathology	Postoperative treatment	Follow-up
Cancer medicines NCCP 00857	Baseline and fertility discussion	Pembrolizumab + carboplatin D1; paclitaxel D1/8/15 ×4 cycles	Pembrolizumab + AC D1 every 3 weeks ×4	Recovery and treatment review	Pembrolizumab: 9 doses every 3 weeks OR 5 doses every 6 weeks	Immune effects can occur after the last dose
Surgery NCCP 00857 · EARLY · NEO	Agree breast and lymph-node plan	Examine response during treatment	Image for surgical planning as needed	Lumpectomy OR mastectomy; lymph-node surgery as indicated	Wound and arm/shoulder recovery	Report new local symptoms
Radiotherapy EARLY	Discuss likely indication	Not part of these chemotherapy cycles	Usually after chemotherapy and surgery	Decision based on surgery and pathology	If indicated: may overlap pembrolizumab under the agreed plan	Review late effects and symptoms
Blood / immune checks NCCP 00857	Blood count, kidney/liver tests, glucose and thyroid tests	Bloods weekly in cycles 1–4; glucose each cycle	Bloods and glucose before each cycle	Continue endocrine/ immune review around surgery	Bloods per pembrolizumab plan; thyroid every 3–6 weeks	Review unresolved or new immune symptoms
Heart checks NCCP 00857 · ESC	Cardiac history / ECG; echo according to anthracycline risk	Review new cardiac symptoms	Doxorubicin exposure: additional monitoring by risk	Tell anaesthetic team about cardiac/immune problems	Cardiac assessment if symptoms or prior toxicity	Risk-based follow-up after anthracycline
Cancer imaging NEO · EARLY	Breast imaging; stage as indicated	Clinical assessment; image if concern	Reassess for surgical planning	Pathology determines response	Agree remaining-breast surveillance	Annual mammography; no routine CT/markers if well

What each check is for

1 Know when the chemotherapy changes

After four 3-week cycles

The weekly paclitaxel visits stop and the AC phase starts.

Ask / act: Confirm which medicines and supportive medicines change.

Sources: NCCP 00857

2 Thyroid and other immune checks

Thyroid tests every 3–6 weeks; glucose each cycle; other tests as indicated

Pembrolizumab can inflame hormone glands and other organs.

Ask / act: Report diarrhoea, breathlessness, severe fatigue, thirst, headache, rash or jaundice promptly.

Sources: NCCP 00857

3 Heart assessment around doxorubicin

Before and during the anthracycline phase, according to risk

Doxorubicin can affect the heart; ECG and echo answer different questions.

Ask / act: Ask whether a baseline echo and follow-up cardiac tests are needed.

Sources: NCCP 00857 · ESC

4 Postoperative medicines and radiotherapy

After pathology and recovery

The team combines recurrence-risk information, tolerance and the operation result.

Ask / act: Ask whether radiotherapy overlaps the remaining pembrolizumab and which clinician coordinates the plan.

Sources: NCCP 00857 · EARLY

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Surveillance and lasting effects

After early breast treatment

Annual mammography of remaining breast tissue after treatment; the team sets the first date. The mastectomy side is not routinely mammographed. New symptoms need assessment between visits.

Ask / act: Report new symptoms early, including after immunotherapy has stopped.

Sources: EARLY

At the next review, ask

- Which treatment phase am I in, and what happens next?
- Which test is expected next, who arranges it, and who explains the result?
- Who should I contact if an expected appointment has not arrived?

This map does not show whether a test has been ordered, booked or completed. Do not wait for a scheduled test if you develop new symptoms.